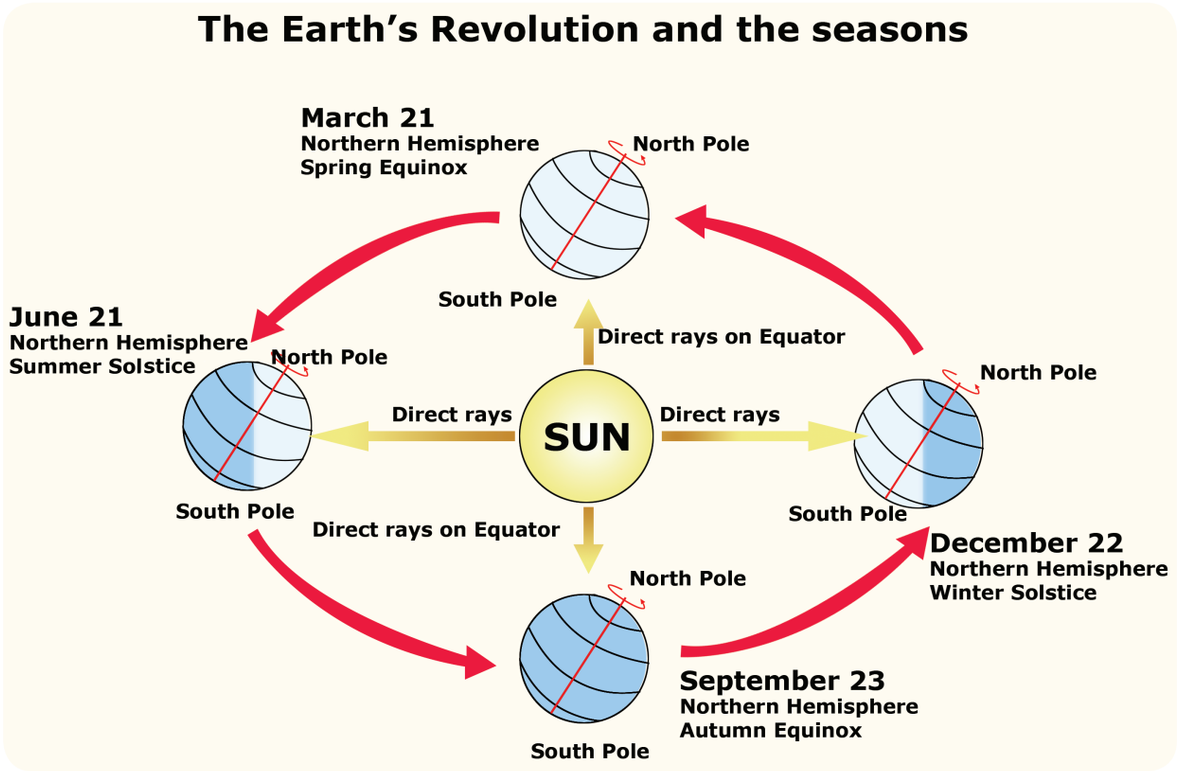


Figure 2.12 Earth's revolution and the seasons

of day light and darkness are equal all over the world. On 21 March the sun is directly overhead at the equator. Throughout the world, on this day all the places experience almost equal hours of day and night. This position of the sun is called spring equinox.

Position of the earth on 23 September

Neither pole of the earth is inclined towards the sun. The rays of the sun fall vertically on the equator. All the places have equal days and nights. It is autumn in the northern hemisphere and spring in the southern hemisphere. Again on 23 September the sun is directly overhead on the equator and it is called autumn equinox. This day (23 September) when sun's rays for fall verticaly on the equator, is known as autumnal equinox (Figure 2.13).

Solstices

Position of the earth on 21 June

The North Pole is inclined or tilted towards the sun. It, therefore, experiences complete light for 24 hours. The South Pole is tilted away from the sun so it is in complete darkness for 24 hours. The rays of the sun fall vertically at the tropic of cancer (23½° N). In the Northern hemisphere, the days are longer than the nights (Table 2.2). It is summer in the northern hemisphere and winter in the southern hemisphere. The day 21 June is known as summer solstice.

Position of the earth on 22 December

The South Pole is inclined towards the sun and the North Pole is away from it. The rays of the sun fall vertically at the tropic of Capricorn (23½° S). The greater part of the southern hemisphere gets the direct rays of the sun so the days are long and

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